But this would mean liberation from ourselves and not just from the British. Vivekananda was searingly honest in his criticism of the social practices that kept India backward. He denounced the oppression of the masses by iniquitous social practices, including caste discrimination. He propagated the idea that 'the divine, the absolute, exists within all human beings regardless of social status'. He also voiced his opposition against the manner in which women were kept, in conditions of servile dependence on men, which made them 'good only to weep at the slightest approach of mishap or danger'. He taught us values that actually mandated change in the arrangements of our society. He refused to accept that religion was cited in favour of iniquitous social practices like child marriage: he was a religious reformer as well as a social reformer. Child marriage, which Rammohan Roy had fought against, still persisted across India, since the British were reluctant to outlaw it. 'A girl of eight is married to a man of thirty and the parents are jubilant over it. And if anyone protests against it, the plea put forward is that our religion is being overturned', he lamented. His devotee Sister Nivedita, born in Britain as Margaret Noble, started a girls' school in Calcutta to advance his progressive ideas about the education of women. He wanted a fully educated India, an objective we have not yet fulfilled a century and a quarter later.

These practices, and the dissensions which divided Hindu society, pained Swami Vivekananda all the more because they were being adhered to in the name of religion. He preached that 'seeing the divine as the essence of others will promote love and social harmony', but he had no illusions about how prevalent such attitudes were. He was furious about those who claimed their beliefs were superior to anyone else's. 'Ask a man who wants to start a sectarian fight,' he declaimed, '"Have you seen God? Have you seen the Atman? If you have not, what right have you to preach his Name—you walking in darkness trying to lead me into the same darkness—the blind leading the blind, and both falling into the ditch?"'

Vivekananda helped create, in his own lifetime, a band of volunteers to work among the poor, the distressed and the marginalised. Many of these were young people, for Swami Vivekananda personified the eternal